The rules the screens assume but nobody has written down

A review of the staging web app (the reference client) for logic that contradicts itself, logic that is quietly broken in the build, and rules that the UI/UX implies but that no one has decided. Each finding says what happens today, why it matters, and a recommended answer, so it can be decided rather than re-asked.

6	16	14	4	4
Critical	High	Medium	Low	Fixed in this pass

Build reviewed
web_app (staging) at 7328ab6, design v2

Date
18 October 2026

Method
Code reading, driving the app at 402 / 540 / 1280 px, cross-checked against PRD and FOR-PRODUCT

1 Read this first

Most of what follows is not a bug in the usual sense. The prototype is careful, but it was built screen by screen from Figma frames that show the happy path, so the rules *between* screens were never specified. Where a screen needed an answer, engineering picked a plausible one and wrote it in a code comment. That makes the app demo well and leaves the product undefined in exactly the places a backend, a pricing plan, or a real AI will need answers.

Three kinds of finding. BROKEN means the build contradicts itself or its own copy today. MISSING RULE means the UI implies a rule that no one has decided. CONTRADICTION means two documented decisions or screens disagree.

The five to decide first

1. **What the free plan actually limits (A1, A2).** The pause never lifts, and "new sessions are free" makes it unlimited at the same time. These two cancel each other out.
2. **One version model (B1, B2, B3).** Two separate version systems exist and disagree. Publish can be pressed on a cut that is still being built.
3. **Recreate must fork the session you are looking at (C1).** On the player it forks one of three fixed sessions instead.
4. **What a lineage is made of (C3, C6).** Creators are shown "Recreated 9.8k" with nothing behind it, and coin sharing depends on it.
5. **What wins a challenge (F2).** The model says "days completed"; the board ranks by plays; prizes go to creators.

2 Free plan and limits

A1 The "paused until" time is never honoured CRITICAL BROKEN

Today	The cockpit pauses after 3 sends in a thread (`sends >= 3`). The notice says "Edits on this session paused until 5:20 PM", a time stamped as *now + 30 minutes*. Nothing ever checks that time: the composer stays disabled forever for that thread. The number is also arbitrary, set when the limit trips, so two users see different reset times for the same rule. An earlier copy showed 12:00 AM.
Why	The product promises a resume that never happens. It is the first paid-plan moment most users will meet.
Recommend	Pick one window, and store and enforce the reset timestamp against the account rather than the thread. A **daily reset at local midnight** is the easiest to explain.

A2 "New session is always free" makes the limit unlimited CRITICAL CONTRADICTION

Today	The limit counts sends per thread. New Session opens a fresh thread with 3 more sends, and the product owner's rule (U036) is that a new session never counts. A user can therefore generate without limit by pressing New Session every 3 messages.
Why	The cost driver is *generation* (builds and audio), not messages. The current limit protects the cheap thing and leaves the expensive thing open.
Recommend	Keep "explore freely", but count what costs money. Free plan: **N builds per day across all sessions** (for example 5). Unlimited conversation. New sessions are free to *start*; building in them draws from the same daily allowance.

A3 What counts as a "send" is accidental HIGH MISSING RULE

Today	These all count: typed messages, voice notes, suggestion chips ("Make it longer"), the Home hand-off, a reply, and **"Apply new changes"** (it writes a user line into the thread). Messages written by a "door" (Recreate, Quick Start) do not count. A user who types one sentence and presses Apply has used 2 of 3.
Recommend	Count builds, not lines (see A2). If lines must count, exclude Apply and the suggestion chips.

A4 Upgrade has no defined benefit HIGH MISSING RULE

Today	The /upgrade screen has Monthly and Annual plans, but nothing defines what paying removes or adds. The coin balance, the limit, and premium prizes from challenges are not connected to it.
Recommend	Write one table: **Free vs Premium** per resource (builds per day, session length, voices, publishing, analytics). Every limit screen then links to the row it is about.

3 Versions and publishing

B1 Two version systems that do not know about each other HIGH BROKEN

Today	**The cockpit** records real builds with ids `v0, v1, v2…` and labels like "Sleep meditation v1.2". **Progress → Version History** always shows two hard-coded cuts, ids `v3` and `v2` ("v1.3", "v1.2"), whatever was actually built. Progress decides "current" by comparing the cockpit's id with its own. They never match, except by collision: cockpit `v2` and Progress `v2` are different cuts. A build made in chat never appears in Progress.
Recommend	A session owns one ordered list of versions. Cockpit, Progress, the player (`?v=`) and the new Details history all read it.

B2 Version numbering has no scheme HIGH MISSING RULE

Today A build adds 0.1 (v1.2 → v1.3). A Quick Start begins at whatever its title says. A fork is named "<title> v2" (a major bump on someone else's title). The catalogue never shows a v1.1. A creator cannot tell what "v2" means next to "v1.3".

Recommend Version numbers belong to a session, never to a title. The first build is **v1.0** and each build adds +0.1. A fork is a *new session* starting at v1.0, which records "built on <parent> v1.3". Drop the "v2" suffix from fork titles.

B3 Publish can be pressed on a cut that is still building HIGH BROKEN

Today The Publish/Republish menu item depends only on whether the current version is live, not on whether it is generating. Publishing mid-build marks the unfinished cut as the live one.

Recommend Publish and Republish are disabled while a build is in progress, with the reason shown ("Finishing v1.4…").

B4 "Live" vs "current" was never defined MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today A creator can publish v1.3, then build v1.4 or revert to v1.2. Listeners presumably still get v1.3, but before U037 no screen said so.

Recommend State the rule and keep it visible. **Live** is what listeners get and changes only on Republish. **Current** is what you are editing. U037 now shows both labels ("Live", "You are here") in Details.

B5 Any cut is playable by URL MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today `/play/<slug>?v=<id>` plays any version, including cuts of a draft and cuts that were never published.

Recommend Only the creator can play non-live versions. Everyone else always gets the live one.

B6 What "published on" means MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today There was no publish date anywhere. U037 shows "Published" (first publish), "Last updated" (when the live cut was published) and "Live version", derived from mock dates.

Decide If a session is unpublished and republished: does "Published" reset? Do plays, recreations and its challenge ranking survive?

B7 Unpublishing has no defined consequences MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today Unpublish shows a reassuring sheet. It is undefined what happens to recreations already made from the session, its challenge entry, shared links, coins already earned, and people mid-listen.

Recommend Recreations keep working and keep the credit. Shared links show "No longer available" with the creator credited. Challenge entries are withdrawn. Coins already earned stay.

4 Recreate and lineage

C1 Player "Recreate your own version" forks the wrong session CRITICAL BROKEN

Today The three cards (Increase yellow, Less movement, 432Hz) each fork a **fixed** catalogue session: Dolphins frequency, Deep Grounding and 528 Hz Reset. This happens whichever session you are listening to. On "Soft Reset", Recreate → Increase yellow opens a fork of Dolphins frequency. The orb's play button also plays that fixed session.

Recommend The cards fork **the session on screen**, with the card's change already stated. The session detail page already does this.

C2 Lineage steps are names, not sessions HIGH MISSING RULE

Today "Ground floor" (Adam Nilson) and "Deep blue, slower" (Marcus Lee) appear in lineages but are not sessions anywhere. Until U037 every lineage row opened the player of the session you were already on. U037 links a row only when it is a real session.

Decide Must every step be a real, openable session? What is shown when an ancestor is unpublished, deleted, or private?

C3 "Recreated 9.8k" has no data behind it HIGH MISSING RULE

Today The catalogue stores only *ancestry* (where a session came from). It stores no forward link from a session to the sessions built from it. The creator's question is "how many times, by whom, and from which of my versions". It cannot be answered. The U037 See All sheet shows illustrative recent rebuilds, labelled as such in code.

Recommend Store a fork record: `child_session, parent_session, parent_version, created_at`. Counts, "built on v1.3", payouts (C7) and notifications all come from it.

C4 Which version does a fork use? MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Decide Always the live version, or may a user pick an older cut? When the parent is updated later, is the fork told? Can it pull the update?

Recommend Forks always start from the live version. No automatic updates. Optionally notify: "Parent updated to v1.4".

C5 Self-recreation and credit loops MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Decide Can you recreate your own session, or a recreation of your own? If you can, you appear twice in the lineage and may earn twice from the same chain. Can you recreate a draft?

C6 Coin sharing through the lineage HIGH MISSING RULE

Today	The rule "Attribution is not a toggle… the coin split follows the chain" is a decision without numbers. A lineage is a chain, so this is a payout graph. Open since FOR-PRODUCT §9.6.
Recommend	A simple capped rule. For example: the creator keeps 70%, the direct parent gets 20%, all earlier ancestors share 10%, and nothing goes deeper than 3 generations.

5 The cockpit (chat)

D1 There is only ever one conversation HIGH BROKEN

Today	The app keeps a single thread. Opening another session, pressing a Quick Start, joining a challenge or recreating **replaces** it. Nothing lists past conversations. The drawer's "Latest" lists sessions, not chats.
Recommend	One conversation per session, reopened with the session. "Latest" lists conversations.

D2 Hand-offs land in whatever thread is open HIGH BROKEN

Today	"Elaborate on my experience" on the player, and anything typed on Home, are *appended* to the current thread, even when that thread is about a different session. Feedback on session A can end up in session B's conversation and change B.
Recommend	A hand-off about a session opens that session's conversation (D1). A Home ask opens a new one.

D3 A build only progresses while you watch it MEDIUM BROKEN

Today	The progress timer runs inside the chat screen. Leaving mid-build freezes it (for example at 43%) until you come back.
Recommend	A build runs regardless of screen, and a notification or the mini player says "v1.4 is ready".

D4 Recommendations ignore the request; the scores add up MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today	Every request gets the same three cards, each "Improve Score +12%", whether you said "I can't sleep" or "I can't focus". The filter sums them to "+36% combined". "Improve Score" has no defined unit, baseline or meaning. Percent improvements do not add.
Decide	What the score measures, against what baseline, and how combined effects are estimated. The Figma "Increase yellow" card is a *visual* change on an audio product: where is it seen?

D5 "Arrive applied" vs a free choice MEDIUM CONTRADICTION

Today The PRD decision says recommendations arrive applied (you remove, you do not opt in). The screen also reaches "0 of 3 selected" with Add buttons. Nothing defines what Apply means with nothing selected, or whether a user can add a change that is not in the deck.

D6 The core loop has no failure states HIGH MISSING RULE

Today Generation failed or timed out, offline, microphone denied, and a recording too long are all still undesigned (FOR-PRODUCT §7). With a real AI and real audio these are the most common states, not edge cases.

D7 New Session stops what is playing LOW CONTRADICTION

Today Starting a new session silences the current audio. The stated decision is "playback survives leaving the player". Decide which wins.

6 Playback

E1 What counts as a "play" MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today "Played 124k" never changes. The challenge leaderboard ranks by plays. No definition exists: a start, 30 seconds, or a finish? Do replays by the same person count?

Recommend A play is at least 60 seconds or 25% of the session, whichever comes first. Count at most once per listener per day for any ranking.

E2 Floating player lifecycle MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today U037 adds a Close (×) that stops and clears playback. Still undecided: Undo after close, auto-hide after a long pause, and resuming from the last position.

Recommend Close with a 4-second Undo. Auto-hide after 30 minutes paused. Remember the position per session.

E3 Every session is the same 10-second loop LOW BROKEN (KNOWN)

Today A demo shortcut. The scrubber shows 0:10 against a 22:22 duration elsewhere, which testers read as a bug. Worth labelling in demos.

7 Coins, points and challenges

F1 Three currencies, no rules HIGH MISSING RULE

Today	"1,323" coins appear in every header and never change. Challenges award "250 pts" and coin prizes. Recommendations show an "Improve Score". Only the referral reward is defined, and it can be farmed with throwaway emails.
Recommend	One currency (coins), one ledger, and a written earn/spend table before any more screens show it.

F2 What wins a challenge HIGH CONTRADICTION

Today	The challenge model says "a streak people join, ranked by days completed". The leaderboard ranks *sessions* by *plays*. The top-3 prizes (up to a year of premium) go to the creators of the most-played sessions, not to the people who completed the 30 days.
Recommend	Separate the two. **Participants** earn points for completing days (a personal streak, no public rank needed). **Creators** compete on a board of sessions made for the challenge, ranked by qualified plays (E1).

F3 How a session enters a challenge MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today	"Join" opens a chat that says "publish it to be featured", but nothing links a published session to the challenge. There is no state for "joined", "submitted", or "streak broken", and the podium assumes 3 entries.

8 Accounts, data and trust

G1 Open admin and open write endpoints CRITICAL BROKEN (KNOWN)

Today	`/admin` has no authentication. `/api/config` (feature flags, including the site lock), `/api/clicks` (anyone can read or delete analytics) and `/api/annotations` accept anonymous writes.
Recommend	Fix before any real users, starting with admin auth and a shared secret on the three endpoints.

G2 "Is this mine?" is decided by display name HIGH BROKEN

Today	Ownership (profile chrome, version history, "your sessions") compares `author === 'Adam Nilson'`. Two creators with the same name merge. Renaming yourself makes you lose your own sessions.
Recommend	User ids everywhere. Names are display only.

G3 Session lifetime and sign-in HIGH MISSING RULE

Today Sign-in is deliberately forgotten on every load, which suits a demo. The real lifetime, sign-out on mobile, and account deletion (and what happens to published sessions and lineage credit) are not decided. Open since FOR-PRODUCT §9.1.

G4 Click insights need consent before production MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today Click insights (U032–U034) is on by default and records every visitor's screens and taps. It is anonymous and stores no typed text, but there is no notice or consent. If it is promoted to production, that is a privacy-law question, not a design one.

9 Claims and safety

H1 No safety path in a mental-health-adjacent chat CRITICAL MISSING RULE

Today The cockpit invites people to say how they feel. The new feeling chips include "Feeling low". There is no rule for crisis language (self-harm, suicidal ideation): no escalation, no resources, no handover. A keyword mock can ignore this; a real model cannot ship without it.

Recommend A written safety policy: detection, the exact response, local crisis resources, and a pause on generation. Legal and clinical review before launch.

H2 Health outcomes shown as facts CRITICAL MISSING RULE

Today "Reduce stress by 43%", "Resting HR −6 bpm" and "Improve Score +12%" are invented and appear on cards. The "Sessions with Biggest Impact" shelf ranks on them. Some are labelled self-reported; card copy ("This helped Adam reduce stress by 43%") is not.

Recommend Decide which outcome claims may appear at all, how they are measured, and the exact disclaimer. Until then, show no numeric health claims on cards.

H3 Publishing has no review HIGH MISSING RULE

Today Anyone can publish a session (voice, text, claims) to the community instantly. There is no review, report, or takedown flow.

H4 A switched-off signal MEDIUM MISSING RULE

Today Sessions are personalised on signals (sleep, heart rate). If the user later turns a signal off, should the session be regenerated, frozen, or should it warn the user? Open since FOR-PRODUCT §9.5.

10 Process

I1 Staging opens on a different app than production LOW CONTRADICTION

Today	Production is pinned to design v2. Staging defaults to v1 unless the reviewer switches. Feedback from staging is often about an app production no longer ships.
Recommend	Default staging to v2.

I2 Web and mobile drift LOW PROCESS

Today	The Flutter app does not yet have feeling chips, reply, the Play rule, click insights, or the U037 changes. It also shares the reply rules, so it is one rule behind.

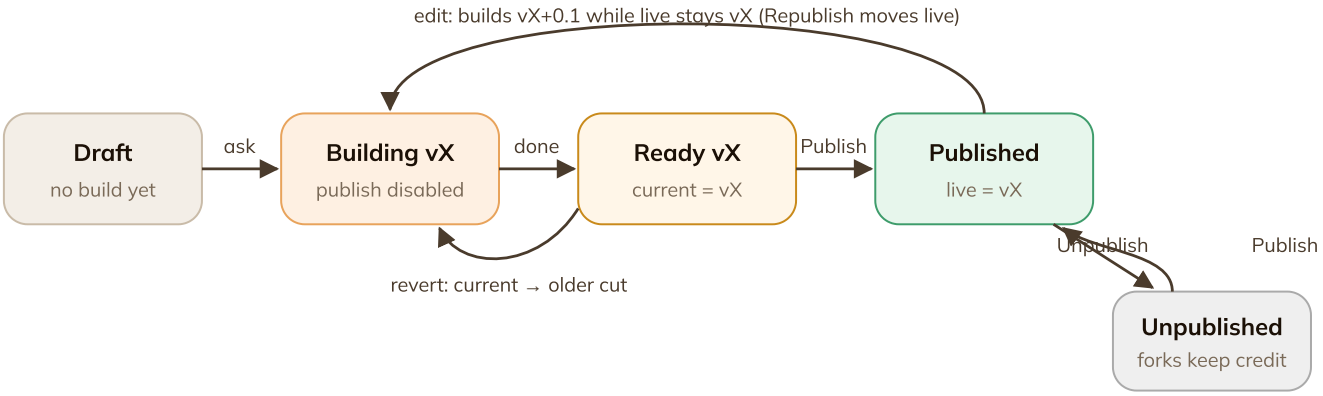
11 Decisions needed, with a recommended default

These are the questions that keep coming back. Each has a default you can accept as-is, so engineering is no longer blocked.

	QUESTION	RECOMMENDED DEFAULT	UNBLOCKS
1	What does the free plan limit?	Builds per account per day (for example 5). Conversation unlimited. Resets at local midnight.	A1–A3
2	What does Premium add?	More builds per day, longer sessions, all voices, analytics.	A4
3	Version numbering	v1.0 first build, +0.1 per build, per session. A fork is a new session at v1.0.	B1, B2
4	Live vs current	Live changes only on (Re)publish. No publishing while building. Non-live cuts are creator-only.	B3–B5
5	Unpublish consequences	Recreations stay and keep credit. Links say "no longer available". Earned coins stay.	B6, B7
6	Fork source	Always the live version. Record parent and version. No automatic updates.	C3, C4
7	Lineage membership	Every step is a real session. Private or deleted steps show "Private session" with credit kept.	C2
8	Lineage payouts	70 / 20 / 10, at most 3 generations. No payout to yourself from your own chain.	C5, C6
9	Conversation model	One conversation per session, listed under "Latest". Hand-offs open the right one.	D1, D2
10	What is a play	At least 60 seconds or 25% of the session. Once per listener per day for rankings.	E1, F2
11	Challenge winners	Participants: personal streak and points. Creators: a board of challenge sessions ranked by qualified plays.	F2, F3
12	One currency	Coins only, with a written earn/spend table. Rename "pts".	F1
13	Safety and claims	Crisis policy and no numeric health claims on cards until measured. Clinical and legal review.	H1–H3
14	Identity and lifetime	User ids. A 30-day rolling session. Delete account keeps lineage credit as "Former member".	G2, G3
15	Analytics consent	Consent notice before click insights runs on production.	G4

12 Proposed session lifecycle

A single state model would answer B1–B7 at once. The arrows show what a creator can do; listeners only ever see the **Live** cut.



13 Fixed in this pass (U037)

✓1 Recommendation cards are one height FIXED

A card with a two-line description no longer pushes its Add button below its neighbours'.

✓2 Lineage "See All" works, and the counts agree FIXED

It was a dead button counting 3 (player) or a hard-coded 10 (Progress) under three rows. It now opens the full tree: where the session came from, each step's "built on <parent> v1.x", and recent rebuilds with the version they used. Rows link only to sessions that exist. A lineage date in the future (2026.12.10) was corrected.

✓3 The mini player can be closed FIXED

× stops and clears the parked session in the cockpit and the floating player.

✓4 Details show publishing and the creator's version history FIXED

"Published / Last updated / Live version", or "Not published" for a draft. On your own sessions, a version timeline marks **Live** and **You are here**. It shares ids with Progress so `?v=` means the same cut everywhere. B1 still applies to builds made in the cockpit.

Prepared from the staging build at commit 7328ab6. Evidence for each finding is in the codebase (file paths in docs/UPDATE-LOG.md, U037), and the open questions continue FOR-PRODUCT §7–§9.